/cancel

Request cancellation of a sub-agent task or a benchmark (/cancel | /cancel help)

Overview

`/cancel` asks a running task to stop, resolved by ID prefix. It targets two places: the active benchmark task (cancelling it raises the bench cancel flag and asks the benchmark loop to stop cooperatively) and the sub-agent tasks the Agents window is tracking.

For a sub-agent task the command **delegates to the task registry**: it resolves the prefix, then calls `AgentManager::cancel_agent` - the same method behind the `cancel_agent` tool - and reports the *request*. It does not remove the row. The task's entry stays `running` until its agent loop observes the cooperative cancel flag at the next step boundary, and the Agents window retires the row when the `SubagentCancelled` event (or the registry reconciliation) reports the transition. That is deliberate: the window mirrors the registry, so a row removed before the registry confirms would reappear on the next sweep and would make a real cancellation indistinguishable from a cosmetic one.

A prefix is matched with `starts_with` on the raw ID, no case folding. Because a prefix can match several tasks, the command refuses an ambiguous one and lists the matches. `/cancel help` prints the subcommand table; an empty argument is a usage error.

Syntax

```
/cancel <task_id_prefix>
/cancel help
```

Options / Subcommands

Form	Description
`/cancel <task_id_prefix>`	Request cancellation of a sub-agent task or benchmark by ID prefix
`/cancel help`	Show the `/cancel` help table

Notes:

- Benchmark tasks take precedence: when the prefix matches `active_bench_task_id`, the bench cancellation flag is set and the status bar shows a wait marker; the benchmark stops between steps, not mid-step.
- Sub-agent tasks: the prefix is matched against every task the Agents window is tracking. Exactly one match is forwarded to the registry; more than one is refused; none lists the live ids.
- "Live" means `running`, `suspended` or `terminating`. A `completed`, `failed`, `cancelled` or `timed_out` task is never offered as a cancel target.
- The task keeps running until its next step boundary, so the status bar reports a request, not an outcome.

Examples

```
/cancel a1b2c3
```

`/cancel bench`

Cancel a benchmark (status bar):

`bench: cancellation requested`

Cancel a sub-agent task (status bar names the request):

`Cancellation requested for a1b2c3d4 (coder)`

`/cancel help`

Missing argument (status bar + warn log):

`[warn] Please provide a task ID prefix: /cancel <id>`

Ambiguous prefix (refused, every match listed):

`[err] Ambiguous task prefix `explore-` - 2 tasks match.`

`explore- (explore, running), explore- (plan, running)`

No match (the live ids are listed, not just the prefix):

`[err] No live task matches `zzzz`.`

`Live tasks: a1b2c3d4 (coder), e5f6a7b8 (explore)`

Already finished:

`[warn] Task a1b2c3d4 (coder) is already `completed` - there is nothing to cancel.`

Output

- On benchmark cancel: status bar `bench: cancellation requested`, Info log `Benchmark cancellation requested for <prefix>`.
- On task cancel: status bar `Cancellation requested for <8-char id> (<agent>)`, Info log `[stop] Cancel requested for task <8-char id> (<agent>)` attributed to the child session, and an assistant bubble `From: /cancel <8-char id>` stating that the task keeps running until its next step boundary. The row is **not** removed; the Agents window updates when the registry reports the transition.
- On an ambiguous prefix: status bar `Ambiguous task prefix '<prefix>'`, a Warn log naming every match, and an assistant bubble listing them as `<short id> (<agent>, <status>)` asking for a longer prefix. Nothing is cancelled.
- On no match: status bar `No task matching '<prefix>'`, a Warn log, and an assistant bubble listing the live task ids (or saying there are none).
- On a finished task: status bar `Task <short id> is already <status>`, a Warn log, and an assistant bubble saying there is nothing to cancel.
- `/cancel help` appends an assistant bubble `From: /cancel help` with the subcommand table; status shows `cancel: help`.

Related

- `/bench` - run benchmarks that produce the cancellable bench task
- Background sub-agents are spawned with `new_agent` and listed in the Agents window (`Alt+A`); `cancel_agent` is the tool-side equivalent of this command

- `/help` - list all available slash commands